

women remain on leadership paths while balancing caregiving responsibilities.

“Building networks, sharing successes, and ensuring decision-makers are aware of contributions can have a powerful impact,” Purushothaman adds. “Too often, we teach women to be grateful for the opportunities they receive. I want them to get comfortable moving past gratitude and asking for what they need and want. Negotiation is not a single conversation, it’s an ongoing process of visibility and advocacy. Preparation, confidence, and leverage of allies can make a real difference.”

Krishnan backs this view, emphasising the importance of self-belief and strategic self-advocacy. “It’s about knowing your worth, building the ability to negotiate clearly, and leveraging data and competence to make your case. Women often hold themselves to

tools, organisations ensure each role’s value is objectively measured, reducing the influence of unconscious biases and historical inconsistencies in pay,” he says.

Performance and risk management are integrated through robust incentive programmes.

Short-term incentives like variable pay and annual bonuses, as well as long-term incentives such as stock options and performance shares, are tied to clearly defined, measurable outcomes.

Senior leaders’ incentives typically include financial performance, strategic achievements, and risk management effectiveness. With ESG goals gaining prominence, compensation may also link to sustainability objectives.

In male-dominated sectors such as manufacturing, energy, and infrastructure, progressive organisations are adopting practices to achieve gender-balanced



“ The biggest barrier keeping mid-career and senior women from achieving pay parity is structural and cultural bias”

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“ Unless women are deliberately supported, the pool of qualified women for board positions will continue to be unduly constrained”

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impossibly high standards, which can undermine their advocacy. Asking doesn’t cost anything, the worst you get is a no. Leveraging your voice, storytelling, visibility, and making informed career choices are all ways to shift perceptions and assert your value.”

Krishnan notes that understanding the psychology behind leadership and pay parity is key. Effective self-advocacy not only changes how women are perceived but can also fundamentally transform how they see themselves, strengthening both confidence and career outcomes.

HOW COMPANIES CAN BRIDGE THE GAP

Organisations are increasingly recognising the need to address unconscious biases regarding pay at senior leadership levels. Joseph notes a key strategy: anchoring compensation around transparent and objective job evaluation frameworks.

“By using independent, standardised evaluation

executive pay. Joseph highlights initiatives including annual pay equity analyses with external consultants, increasing pay transparency, de-biasing performance evaluations and promotion processes, linking CEO compensation to diversity goals, and publicly disclosing executive compensation and equity metrics.

Purushothaman adds that lasting change requires combining structural measures with cultural accountability, particularly in hierarchical Indian workplaces.

“Transparent pay frameworks, regular audits, standardised evaluations, clear career paths, flexible work policies, reintegration programmes, and paid parental leave are critical. Equally important is fostering a culture of sponsorship, where managers actively advocate for women and amplify their visibility. When organisations track progress, hold leaders accountable, and align incentives with equity, women are more likely to advance fairly, and compensation aligns with contribution.” **BT**